

WRITING MASTERBOOK

Targeted guidance, worked examples and original practice. Use after an attempt, then transfer the correction to a new context.

The four parts: purpose before language

Part 1 has five personal replies of one to five words. Give the requested information directly. Part 2 asks for 20-30 words in connected sentences. Part 3 has three separate posts of 30-40 words each. Part 4 requires an informal email of 40-50 words and a formal email of 120-150 words about the same announcement.

For a full 50-minute practice, try 3 minutes for Part 1, 7 for Part 2, 10 for Part 3 and 30 for Part 4. These are a training allocation within the official total, not separate compulsory time limits. Planning and checking belong inside those periods.

Before drafting, identify the audience, every requested action, the facts you must preserve and the word range. A sophisticated sentence cannot compensate for answering a different question. In the course, B2/B2+ refers to the teaching target; practice marks are not converted into official Aptis levels.

Part 2: answer both halves economically

Prompt: You have joined a walking group. Explain why you joined and when you can usually attend. Weak answer: "Walking is very interesting and there are many reasons why people enjoy it." This is grammatical but gives neither the personal reason nor availability.

Stronger model: "I joined to explore nearby routes and meet people who enjoy walking. I am usually free on Sunday mornings, although I sometimes work at weekends." (25 words.) The answer spends its limited space on the two requested points.

Do not add a formal greeting to every short response. Use one or two complete sentences, check articles and prepositions, and remove general statements that could fit any topic.

Part 3: develop one useful idea per post

A reliable pattern is answer + reason + concrete detail. It is a flexible way of developing content, not a sentence template to memorise. A comparison may need answer + contrast instead; a personal experience may need event + consequence.

Prompt: Should a club publish notes after meetings? Weak: "Yes, it is good and useful. I agree because it is a good idea for everyone." The repetition creates length without development.

Stronger model: "Publishing brief notes would help members who cannot attend, especially those working irregular shifts. The notes need not repeat every comment; they should record decisions and next steps so everyone can prepare for the following meeting." (36 words.)

Each post has its own purpose. Do not spend the first ten words repeating the question or begin every response with the same phrase. Personal examples are useful when they clarify the point rather than distract from it.

Part 4: plan one situation for two readers

Read the announcement once for facts and once for implications. Make a short plan for each email before writing either. For a friend, choose a natural reaction and a shared next step. For an organiser, identify the issue, explain a specific effect and propose a realistic request.

Example announcement: a weekend workshop has moved to Tuesday afternoon. Existing payments may transfer to a later weekend course. Do not claim the workshop is cancelled or that refunds are guaranteed. Accuracy about the notice is part of task fulfilment.

Informal model: "Hi Mia, the workshop has moved to Tuesday afternoon, so I cannot attend after all. I am disappointed, but we can transfer our payments to the next weekend course. Shall we ask which dates are available and choose one together? Speak soon, Jo." (43 words.)

Formal model: "Dear Workshop Coordinator, I am writing about the move from Saturday to Tuesday afternoon. I understand that finding a suitable room may be difficult, but the new time prevents me from attending because I work until five. Other members may face a similar problem. I appreciate the option to transfer our payments to a later weekend course. Could you let us know which dates are available and whether our places can be reserved before the new course

opens for general booking? It would also help to receive an outline of the programme, so that we can check whether it covers the same material. I would be grateful for this information by Friday, when I need to arrange my work schedule. Thank you for your assistance. Yours sincerely, Jo Patel." (129 words.)

The formal model acknowledges a possible constraint without inventing it as a confirmed fact. It explains the impact, uses the transfer option correctly and asks for information the organiser could provide. Its polite tone comes from a proportionate request and clear reasoning.

Register: change the relationship, not only the vocabulary

To a friend: "I am annoyed about the short notice. Could we go next month instead?" To an organiser: "The short notice makes it difficult to rearrange work commitments. Could you confirm whether a later session is available?" Both are direct, but the second explains an impact relevant to a decision.

Contractions can be natural in an informal email. Formal writing does not require long words or an apology in every sentence. "Could you clarify the deadline?" is more useful than "I hereby wish to express my profound desire for clarification."

A greeting and close should fit the relationship. "Hi Alex" and "See you soon" suit a friend. "Dear Coordinator" and "Yours sincerely" can suit an identified role when no personal name is supplied. Consistency matters more than inserting ceremonial phrases.

Paraphrase, cohesion and precision

Preserve the strength of a claim. "May reduce attendance" cannot safely become "will prevent everyone from attending". Preserve conditions too: "free for members" does not mean "free for all visitors". A useful paraphrase changes wording while keeping scope, certainty and relationships.

Use connectors to show a real link. However introduces contrast; therefore marks a result; for example introduces supporting detail. Adding them mechanically can imply a relationship the ideas do not have.

Reduce repetition through reference, not a thesaurus at every noun. After naming "the revised timetable", use "this arrangement" if the reference is clear. Replacing every repeated word with an unusual synonym can make the message less precise.

Weak: "The room is small. The room is noisy. The room is not suitable." Stronger: "The room is both small and noisy, so it may be unsuitable for a discussion involving twenty people." The revision connects evidence to a qualified conclusion.

Edit to the word range without losing the task

Cut empty framing first: "I am writing this email because I would like to tell you that" often becomes "I am writing about" or disappears. Next remove duplicated reasons, unnecessary quotations and unsupported background. Protect the requested content points.

If an answer is short, develop the reasoning rather than padding it. Explain who is affected, give one example, or show why the suggested action is feasible. Count each Part 3 response separately and each Part 4 email separately.

Use one consistent counting convention during practice: words separated by spaces, with contractions and hyphenated forms counted as one. The actual test provides a counter; follow it when taking the exam. Model counts in these materials follow the stated practice convention.

A three-pass self-edit

Pass 1, task: mark where you answer each request. Check the announcement facts and the reader. Pass 2, meaning: check the order of ideas, ambiguous pronouns and whether the request is realistic. Pass 3, language: check your two most frequent errors, then spelling, punctuation and word count.

Common B2 repairs: "discuss about the plan" becomes "discuss the plan"; "suggest to change" becomes "suggest changing"; "an advice" becomes "some advice"; "despite it is late" becomes "although it is late"; "I would appreciate if" becomes "I would appreciate it if".

After correction, record only useful patterns in the Error Tracker. Include the original ID, the reason for the correction and a new personal example. Revisit it after two days and again a week later. A sentence you can repair once is not necessarily

a pattern you can use under time pressure.

Mini-drills | answers in the Complete Answer Book

MBW-E01 | PARAPHRASE AND PRESERVE CERTAINTY

Attempt each repair before consulting the Answer Book. Suggested answers are not the only valid wording.

MBW-E01-Q01

Rewrite: "The later start may make attendance difficult for some members." Preserve both qualifications.

MBW-E01-Q02

Rewrite: "Members can transfer their payment, but a refund has not been confirmed." Keep the distinction.

MBW-E02 | REPAIR REGISTER

Attempt each repair before consulting the Answer Book. Suggested answers are not the only valid wording.

MBW-E02-Q01

To an organiser, improve: "Your plan is rubbish. Change it now." Include a practical request.

MBW-E02-Q02

To a friend, improve: "I would be grateful if you could indicate whether you intend to participate."

MBW-E03 | REPAIR COHESION

Attempt each repair before consulting the Answer Book. Suggested answers are not the only valid wording.

MBW-E03-Q01

Link these ideas without changing them: "The hall is cheaper. It is far from public transport. Some members may struggle to reach it."

MBW-E03-Q02

Remove repetition: "The new schedule is useful. The new schedule gives us more notice. The new schedule helps us plan."

MBW-E04 | EDIT A WORD-COUNT PROBLEM

Attempt each repair before consulting the Answer Book. Suggested answers are not the only valid wording.

MBW-E04-Q01 | 20-30 words

Write 20-30 words answering both points: Why did you join a repair group, and what can you contribute? Start from: "I joined because I think repairing things is a very interesting activity and I am interested in it. I can help people because I have some experience of repairing bicycles."

MBW-E05 | CHOOSE A USEFUL FINAL CHECK

Attempt each repair before consulting the Answer Book. Suggested answers are not the only valid wording.

MBW-E05-Q01

You have one minute left after writing a formal email. Name three checks with a higher priority than replacing common words with unusual synonyms.
